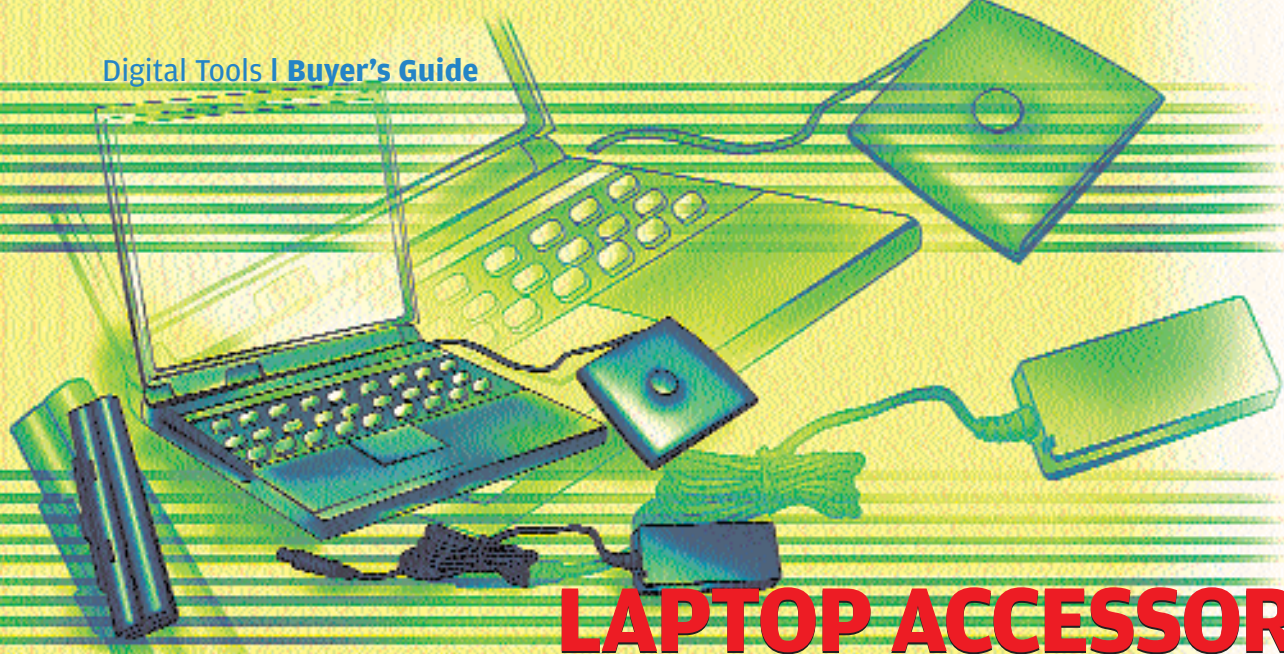




LAPTOP ACCESSORIES

Desktop computers today happen to be some of the most powerful computers ever made! Unfortunately, they aren't portable! But laptops are now rivalling desktop computers in terms of processing power. And we're not just talking about working with spreadsheets or word documents; it's also about multimedia and gaming.

However, since laptops are meant to be carried around, there are some issues they all have to contend with. These include issues such as cooling, battery life, and more. With rising laptop sales everywhere, manufacturers have been made to sit up and take notice. This has brought about interesting innovations that improve your laptop computing experience—which is what we'll talk about here.

Questions to ask the dealer

Does the product come from a well-known company?

There are plenty of no-name companies in the market that make laptop accessories; the quality of these isn't great, and some can actually harm your laptop.

What is the warranty available on the product?

Some dealers are reluctant to give any warranty at all on products such as Bluetooth dongles, USB hubs, cheap headphones, etc.

If the product goes bad, will it be replaced, or will it be repaired?

Replacement is the option you should be looking at.

What is the turnaround time for the product if it has to be repaired?

Will you be provided with a stop-gap solution during this period? Most dealers will be reluctant to answer this question.

Usage tips

Accessories available for the laptop range from batteries to exotic-cooling systems that keep a laptop running cool for hours on end.

❑ **Extra Batteries:** If your work involves a lot of hours with the laptop, you should definitely consider getting yourself an extra battery pack.

❑ **Laptop Cooler:** This is a must-buy for any laptop user. Irrespective of how long they are used, laptops have a tendency

to get warm. Those with poor ventilation can run really hot. Laptop coolers generally consist of large cooling fans that run really quiet and provide efficient cooling. Power consumption is very low, at a max of 110 mW, with the cooler drawing power from the laptop's USB port.



❑ **Connectivity dongles:** In today's age of Bluetooth and FireWire, it is a drawback to not have these connectivity options on your laptop. Off-the-shelf USB devices are available that connect to the USB port on the laptop, and offer you the power of using both Bluetooth and FireWire devices on the go!

❑ **Speakers:** So you're in this hotel room far away from home, and want to listen to some music. But you'd rather listen to silence than your tinny laptop speakers! Well, there happen to be speakers available for just this kind of situation. Laptop speakers connect to the laptop's sound card, and in most cases are self-powered. Some manufacturers also offer USB connectivity, where the speakers connect to the laptop using the USB port and draw power from the port.

❑ **USB mouse and keyboard:** Not many people are comfortable with the touchpad, or with the pointing stick for that matter. Laptop keyboards are cramped in most cases, and are un-ergonomic. A USB mouse and keyboard can provide considerable relief. ■

Points To Ponder

We're here assuming you already have a laptop and are looking to purchase accessories for it. Now, it's only you who can determine your usage pattern and identify issues related to it. Here's a list we think should be foremost on your mind when you're buying an accessory for your laptop.

What is the number of hours you use your laptop for at a stretch?

As you've probably experienced, laptops have a tendency to generate a lot of heat, more so with poorly-designed laptops that have little or no room for ventilation. Also, are you doing yourself harm by working so long at the laptop?

Does your laptop consume a lot of power?

Calculate the amount of time your laptop battery runs. If it doesn't run long enough for you, consider a battery pack.

Does your laptop have the necessary connectivity options for you to remain truly mobile?

By connectivity options, we mean Bluetooth, FireWire etc.

Do you use your laptop mostly for work and for some entertainment, or vice-versa?

This is important since if you are looking for entertainment on the move, your priority of laptop accessories will be different from that of users who use the laptop solely for work.